Chau Tong

Curriculum vitae
October 2026
Missouri School of Journalism & Institute for Data Science & Informatics
University of Missouri, Columbia, MO
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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

2023- Assistant Professor (Joint Appointment), Missouri School of Journalism and Institute for Data Science & Informatics, University of Missouri.

2021-23 Postdoctoral Associate, Department of Communication, Cornell University.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., University of Wisconsin-Madison, Madison, Wisconsin
Mass Communications, School of Journalism and Mass Communication, 2021

M.A., Ewha Womans University, Seoul, South Korea
Communication, 2013

B.A., Hanoi College of Foreign Language, Hanoi, Vietnam
English, 2009

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Computational social science; algorithmic gatekeepers and generative AI; platform and search audits; health and political communication; digital information equity; networked public discourse.

RESEARCH

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed journal articles

2026 **Tong, C.,** Eyinla, T., & Bautista, J. R. "Comparing BERTopic Outputs with Human-Coded Themes: The Alignment and Usefulness Rating Audit (AURA) Workflow for Qualitative Analysis." *International Journal of Qualitative Methods.* doi: 10.1177/16094069261486252.

2025 Shea, A., Omapang, A., Cho, J.Y., Ginsparg, M., Bazarova, N., Winice, H., Kizilcec, R., **Tong, C.**, & Margolin, D. "Beyond ad hominem attacks: A typology of the discursive tactics used when objecting to news commentary on social media." *PLOS ONE*. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0328550.

2025 Massey, Z., **Tong, C.**, Zhang, T., Wexell, K., Li, Y., & Zhao, J. “Assessing responses to cannabis health warnings among adults in U.S. recreational states.” *American Journal of Preventive Medicine*. doi:10.1016/j.amepre.2025.107998.

2025 **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Niederdeppe, J., Chunara, R., Liu, J., Jih-Vieira, L., & King, A. “Colorectal Cancer Racial Equity Post Volume, Content, and Exposure: An Observational Study Using Twitter (now X) Data.” *Journal of Medical Internet Research*. doi:10.2196/63864.

2024 Liu, J., Niederdeppe, J., **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Chunara, R., Smith, T., & King, A. “Associations between news coverage, social media discussions, and search trends about celebrity deaths, screening, and other colorectal cancer-related events.” *Preventive Medicine*, 185. doi:10.1016/j.ypmed.2024.108022.

2023 King, A. J., Dunbar, N. M., Margolin, D., Chunara, R., **Tong, C.**, Jih-Vieira, L., Matsen, C., & Niederdeppe, J. “Global prevalence and content of information about alcohol use as a cancer risk factor on Twitter.” *Preventive Medicine*, 177. doi:10.1016/j.ypmed.2023.107728.

2022 **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Chunara, R., Niederdeppe, J., Taylor, T., Dunbar, N., & King, A. J. “Search Term Identification Methods for Computational Health Communication: A Word Embedding and Network Approach for Health Content on YouTube.” *JMIR Medical Informatics*, 10(8). doi:10.2196/37862.

2022 Suk, J., Lukito, J., Su, M., Kim, S. J., Tong, C., Sun, Z., & Sarma, P. “Do I sound American? How message attributes of Internet Research Agency (IRA) disinformation relate to Twitter engagement.” Computational Communication Research, 4(2), 590–628. doi:10.5117/CCR2022.2.008.SUK.

2022 Ghosh, S., Su, M., Abhishek, A., Suk, J., **Tong, C.**, Kamath, K., Hills, O., Correa, T., Garlough, C., Borah, P., & Shah, D. “Covering #MeToo Across the News Spectrum: Political Accusation and Public Events as Drivers of Press Attention.” *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 27(1), 158-185. doi:10.1177/1940161220968081.

2021 **Tong, C.**, Winckler, H., & Rojas, H. “The Connection Between Perceptions of Media Bias and Influence and Affective Polarization - An Examination in Brazil and Mexico and the United States.” *Revista de Comunicación Política*. doi:10.29105/rcp3-1.

2021 Lukito, J., Loya, L., Dávalos, C., Li, J., **Tong, C.**, & McLeod, D. M. “Chiming In: A Computer-Assisted Analysis of Popular Musicians’ Political Engagement on Twitter.” *Social Media + Society*, 7(2). doi:10.1177/20563051211019013.

2020 **Tong, C.**, Gill, H., Li, J., Valenzuela, S., & Rojas, H. “‘Fake news is anything they say!’—Conceptualization and weaponization of fake news among the American public.” *Mass Communication and Society*, 23(5), 755-778. doi:10.1080/15205436.2020.1789661.

2019 Xia, Y., Lukito, J., Zhang, Y., Wells, C., Kim, S. J., & **Tong, C.** "Disinformation, performed: self-presentation of a Russian IRA account on Twitter." *Information, Communication & Society*, 22(11), 1646-1664. doi:10.1080/1369118X.2019.1621921.

Peer-reviewed conference proceedings

2025 **Tong, C.** "Searching for BLM: Google Search Results During the 2020 Black Lives Matter Protests." In *Adjunct Proceedings of the 33rd ACM Conference on User Modeling, Adaptation and Personalization (UMAP Adjunct '25)*. ACM. doi:10.1145/3708319.3733704.

2025 **Tong, C.** "Unite or divide? Biased search queries and Google Search results in polarized politics." In *Proceedings of the 17th ACM Web Science Conference 2025 (WebSci '25)*, 158-168. ACM. doi:10.1145/3717867.3717888.

Editorially reviewed letters

2023 King, A. J., Margolin, D., **Tong, C.**, Chunara, R., & Niederdeppe, J. "Making sense of social media data about colorectal cancer screening." *Journal of the American College of Radiology*, 21(4), 543-544. doi:10.1016/j.jacr.2023.06.045.

Book reprints

2021 Tong, C., Gill, H., Li, J., Valenzuela, S., & Rojas, H. "'Fake News Is Anything They Say!' Conceptualization and Weaponization of Fake News among the American Public." In D. Pompper & L. Hoffman (Eds.), What IS News? Routledge. Reprinted from Mass Communication and Society, 23(5), 755–778 (2020).

RESEARCH FUNDING

Funded external research

2021-23 **Key personnel**, National Cancer Institute, National Institutes of Health, R37CA259156. "Using natural language processing and crowd-sourcing to monitor and evaluate public information and communication disparities about colon cancer screening." PIs: King, A., Niederdeppe, J., Margolin, D., & Chunara, R.

Funded internal research

2025-27 **Principal Investigator**, Arts and Humanities Research & Creative Works Fellows Program, University of Missouri Office of the Provost, $6,000. "Reclaiming Truth: Analyzing the Cultural and Ethical Impact of Pink Slime Journalism on Local Communities."

Internal research proposals under review

2026 **Sole Principal Investigator**, University of Missouri Research Council, $11,434 requested. "When AI Health Answers Are Uncertain: Connecting Evidence Gaps to Next Steps." Submitted October 19, 2026; decision expected December 2026. Proposed 12-month project period: January–December 2027, tentative. Pending.

Selected other internal proposals

2026 **Principal Investigator**, University of Missouri, Human-Centered Design Seed Grant, $5,000 requested. “Visual Sensemaking for Journalists: Human-Centered Tools for Interpreting AI-Generated Political Satire and Synthetic Media.” Co-Investigator: Xiaolei Guo. Submitted May 19, 2026 (June 2026 deadline). Proposed project period: 12 months, August 2026–August 2027. Not funded.

Selected other external proposals

2026 **Co-Investigator**, American Cancer Society (ACS), $1,102,218. “SHINE: Advancing Understanding of Late Breast Cancer Survivorship (15+ Years) via a Mixed-Methods Exploration of Health and Lived Experience.” Not funded.

2025 **Principal Investigator**, Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, $495,042. “‘Ask-Better’ Search Agent and Ambient Explainability Layer: Co-creating a Bilingual, Equitable Health-Search Future.” Not funded.

2025 **Co-Investigator**, Engagement Scholarship Consortium, $5,000. “Missouri Public Health Workers’ Perceptions and Adoption of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Developing Accurate and Tailored Health Information Materials.” Not funded.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW

2026 Eyinla, T., Sadiq, A., Karra, K., Molina, R., & **Tong, C.** “Availability, Response Stability, and Source Stability in Google AI Overviews: An English–Spanish Longitudinal Audit.” Full paper (12 pages), submitted to *The International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM 2027)*, Edinburgh, Scotland. Under review. Supervising/senior author.

2026 **Tong, C.** & Smith, T. “Framing and Nationalization in Pink Slime Politics.” *Political Communication*. Under review. Supervising/senior author.

HONORS & AWARDS

2025-27 Arts and Humanities Research & Creative Works Fellow, University of Missouri.

2023 CTRSI Scholarship Award, Bronfenbrenner Center for Translational Research, Cornell University.

2020 Dissertation Research Grant, School of Journalism and Mass Communication, University of Wisconsin-Madison, $2,000.

2020 Graduate Student Research Grant Competition, The Graduate School, University of Wisconsin-Madison, $1,500.

2019 Louise Elizabeth George Scholarship (Dissertation Fellowship), University of Wisconsin-Madison, $1,000.

2019 Top Student-led Paper, Political Communication Interest Group, AEJMC, for "Donatenow!: A computer-assisted analysis of musician's political engagement on Twitter."

2018 Second-Top Student Paper, Ethnicity & Race Division, ICA, for "White Elitism, Passive Empathy and the Modern Ideological Discourse on the Suffering of the Other."

2016 Top 4 Paper Award, Health Communication Division, ICA, for "The Interplay between Verbal Frames and Images in Influencing News Readers' Perceptions of the Social Determinants of Obesity."

2011-13 Korean Government Cultural Exchange Scholarship, Ewha Womans University.

REFEREED CONFERENCE PAPER PRESENTATIONS

2026 Kim, S., Lei, C., Ssozi, J., **Tong, C.,** Li, J., & Nzau, T. Performative Fact-Checking - Epistemic Mimicry in Grok's Responses on X. Presentation, 2026 APSA Pre-Conference in Political Communication, Boston University.

2026 Bautista, J. R., & **Tong, C.** "Lessons learned in using computational text analysis methods to analyze unstructured interview data in nursing research." Poster discussion, Midwest Nursing Research Society 50th Annual Research Conference, St. Louis, MO.

2025 **Tong, C.**, & Bautista, J. R. "Health communication and AI in nursing: comparative analysis of generative AI tool perceptions among nursing faculty, practitioners, and students." Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication, San Francisco, CA.

2025 Wang, N., Schroeder, M., **Tong, C.**, & Guadalupe, M. "Internalizing the stigma: Patient reflections of weight-based conversation in primary care visits." National Communication Association, Aurora, CO.

2025 **Tong, C.**, Hatley, M., Smith, T., Jenkins, J. M., & Kiesow, D. M. "From Fabrication to Influence: Investigating the Electoral Effects of Pink-Slime Journalism." Local Journalism Researchers Workshop, University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill.

2024 King, A., Chen, T., Wicke, R., **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Chunara, R., Kanrar, R., Nettleton, R., & Niederdeppe, J. "Understanding colorectal cancer screening message preferences of Black Americans: Results from a crowdsourced Wiki survey." American Public Health Association Annual Meeting, Minneapolis.

2024 Massey, Z., **Tong, C.**, Zhang, T., Wexell, K., Kumar, T. M. R., & Li, Y. "Reactions to cannabis health warnings as outcomes and predictors: Mixed method results from a national experiment with people who use cannabis." American Public Health Association Annual Meeting, Minneapolis.

2024 Jenkins, J., Mathews, N., **Tong, C.**, Kiesow, D., Khanom, A., Babel, A., et al. "Computational Methods in Mapping Critical Information Needs." Local Journalism Researchers Workshop, Durham, NC.

2023 Bazarova, N., Shea, A., Hui, W., Margolin, D., **Tong, C.**, Omapang, A., Cho, J. Y., Ginsparg, M., & Kizilcec, R. "Discursive objection strategies used in online comments: Developing a classification schema and validating its training." International Communication Association, Toronto, Canada.

2022 **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., King, A., Niederdeppe, J., & Chunara, R. "Who Endorses and How? Application of Automated Linguistic Analysis and Supervised Machine Learning to Detect Persuasion Strategies in Colorectal Cancer Screening Messages for Whites and Black Americans on Twitter." National Communication Association, New Orleans, LA.

2022 King, A., **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Niederdeppe, J., Chunara, R., & Kwanho, K. "Prevalence and Content of Messages in the Public Communication Environment about Alcohol Use as a Modifiable Risk Factor." Society for Risk Analysis Annual Conference, Tampa, FL.

2022 **Tong, C.**, Nguyen, N., Ha, H., Do, H., & Vu, H. "Dealing with Misinformation on COVID-19: Comparing the Use of Transparency and Accessibility in Fact-Checking Practices across 74 Countries." Symposium on Misinformation and Global Communication.

2022 **Tong, C.**, Margolin, D., Chunara, R., Niederdeppe, J., Taylor, T., Dunbar, N., & King, A. "Search Term Identification Methods for Computational Health Communication: A Similarity-Based Approach for Health Content on YouTube." International Communication Association.

2022 **Tong, C.** "Exploring the Relationship between Political Ideology and Confirmation Bias in Web Search." International Communication Association.

2021 **Tong, C.** "Examining the Mediating Role of Search Efficacy, Algorithmic Knowledge, and Perceived Accuracy on the Use of Online Search for Political Information: A Structural Equation Modeling Approach." National Communication Association.

2021 **Tong, C.**, & Diakopoulos, N. "Searching for BLM: Search behavior and Google results during the 2020 Black Lives Matter protests." International Communication Association.

2020 **Tong, C.** "Who Prefers Algorithmic Filtering of Political News? Examining Individual and Partisan Susceptibility to News Personalization." Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication. Poster presentation.

2020 **Tong, C.** "Partisan Personalization in Google Search Results." Communication and Technology Division Doctoral Consortium, International Communication Association.

2020 **Tong, C.** "The Political Use of Search Engines: Differences in the Information Seeking Habits between Right-leaning and Left-leaning Users." AEJMC Midwinter Conference, Oklahoma.

2019 **Tong, C.**, & Wang, S. "'Tumblrpocalypse': Patterns of User and Community Migration Across Social Media Platforms." ICA Post-Conference on Creator Governance: Platforms, Policy, Rights, and Regulation, Washington, DC.

2019 Lukito, J., Loya, L., Dávalos, C., Li, J., **Tong, C.**, & McLeod, D. "Donatenow!: A computer-assisted analysis of musician's political engagement on Twitter." AEJMC. Top Student-Led Paper.

2018 **Tong, C.**, & Rojas, H. "Authoritarian Orientation and Political Participation Revisited: The 2016 U.S. Presidential Primaries." International Communication Association, Prague, Czech Republic.

2018 **Tong, C.** "White Elitism, Passive Empathy and the Modern Ideological Discourse on the Suffering of 'the Other'." International Communication Association, Prague, Czech Republic. Second-Top Student Paper.

2018 **Tong, C.** "Job Insecurity and Vote Choice in the 2016 Primaries Election." American Association for Public Opinion Research, Denver, CO.

2016 Liu, J., Kornfield, R., Chen, Y., & **Tong, C.** "The Interplay between Verbal Frames and Images in Influencing News Readers' Perceptions of the Social Determinants of Obesity." International Communication Association, Fukuoka, Japan. Top 4 Paper Award.

2016 **Tong, C.**, & Wagner, M. "The Interplay of News Frames on Information Processing: Probing Processing Styles and Deeply-held Attitudes through Physiological Measures." International Communication Association, Fukuoka, Japan. Poster presentation.

2012 **Tong, C.**, & Lee, G. "Analysis of Hallyu in Vietnamese Media: Objects and Frames of Korean Wave." International Conference on Understanding Korean Cultural Wave in Asia, Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam.

INVITED AND OTHER RESEARCH PRESENTATIONS

2026 **Tong, C.** "When Google Answers Health Questions: Uncertainty, Guidance, and Safeguards in AI Overviews." Invited research talk, Missouri School of Journalism Brown Bag Research Colloquium, October 16.

2026 **Tong, C.** "From concepts to classification: What new methods (MLs/LLMs) can and can't do for social science measurement." Invited talk, J9000 Doctoral Theory Seminar, September 10.

2024 **Tong, C.** "Using Data Science Skills for Social Impact: Computational Social Science." Data Science & Analytics Executive Week, MU Institute for Data Science & Informatics.

2022 **Tong, C.** "Leveraging Big Data and Analytics for Data-driven Discovery and Audience Insights in Communication Research." Missouri School of Journalism and MU Institute for Data Science & Informatics.

2022 **Tong, C.** "Dealing with Misinformation on COVID-19: Comparing the Use of Transparency and Accessibility in Fact-Checking Practices across 74 Countries." Global Fact 9 Conference, online.

2022 **Tong, C.** "Who Prefers Algorithmic Filtering of Political News?" Cornell Alumni Research Poster Open House.

2021 **Tong, C.** "Bias by Design: Combining Old and New Methods to Contextualize Information Engagement, Exposure and Disparities in the Digital Media Environment." Department of Communication, Cornell University.

TEACHING & MENTORING

COURSES TAUGHT

University of Missouri

2025 **Strategic Communication Research Methods**, JOURN 4952, Missouri School of Journalism. Instructor.

2025 **Communication Network Analytics**, DATA_SCI 8220, Institute for Data Science & Informatics. Instructor.

2024 **Introduction to Natural Language Processing with Generative AI**, DATA_SCI 8001, Institute for Data Science & Informatics. Instructor.

2023-26 **Emerging Technologies**, JOURN 7462, Missouri School of Journalism. Instructor; online mode.

Prior teaching

2014-18 **J201: Introduction to Mass Communication**, University of Wisconsin-Madison. Teaching Assistant.

2016-17 **J162: Mass Media in Multicultural America**, University of Wisconsin-Madison. Teaching Assistant; online mode.

2018 **CA345: Online Communication and Interpersonal Relationships**, University of Wisconsin-Madison. Course grader.

CURRICULUM DEVELOPMENT

- Rebuilt Emerging Technologies around generative-AI literacy and critical limitations, including weekly AI/prompt-outcome logs and a no-GenAI research-proposal capstone to protect independent reasoning.
- Scaled Introduction to Natural Language Processing across online and on-campus cohorts with reproducible labs and a research-oriented final paper/proposal.
- Implemented dual-track examples and scaffolded mixed-background teams to support students from journalism and data-science backgrounds while maintaining common learning outcomes.

GRADUATE STUDENT COMMITTEES

Dissertation committees

Current chair (1)

Temitope Eyinla, Ph.D. in Informatics, University of Missouri (2025-present)

Current member (1)

Timoteo Kelly, Ph.D. in Informatics, University of Missouri (2024-present)

Master's committees

Chair (1)

Andrea Beaumont, Journalism, University of Missouri (2025)

Member served to completion (6)

Xu Xu, Journalism (2025); Daiyi Jiang, Journalism (2025); Piyusha Modhave, Data Science & Analytics (2025); Gulli Atakishiyeva, Data Science & Analytics (2024-25); Tarun Kumar, Data Science & Analytics (2024-25); Quinn Dang, Journalism (2025).

Postdoctoral mentoring

Qin Li, Postdoctoral Fellow, Communication, Faculty Mentor (2024-present)

UNDERGRADUATE MENTORSHIP

Independent study / honors research

Krishna Karra, Computer Science (2025-present), Independent Study Supervisor; 2026 Award for Academic Distinction.

Alessia Taranda, Data Science (2025-present), Honors Independent Study Supervisor.

Audrey Walker, Journalism (2025-present), Honors Independent Study Supervisor.

Shiyu Yuan, Journalism (2023-24), Independent Study Supervisor; subsequently entered the Ph.D. program at the University of Southern California.

RESEARCH MENTORING

Sadiq Abiodun, Ph.D. student, Journalism (2025-present), research mentor and co-author.

Na Wang, Ph.D. student, Communication (2024-present), research mentor and co-author.

Michael Hatley, Ph.D. student, Statistics (2024-25), research supervisor and co-author.

Tanner Smith, Communication (2023-present), research mentor and co-author; subsequently entered the Ph.D. program at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.

Vy Luong, Ph.D. student, Journalism (2023-24), research and writing supervision; co-author.

Chandi Dahal, Ph.D. student, Journalism (2023-24), research and writing supervision; co-author.

Sowmya Guda, Master's student, Computer Science (2023-24), research mentor.

Yves de Jesus, M.S. student, Data Science & Analytics (2024), research mentor.

Deshan Wattegama, Ph.D. student, Informatics (2024), research mentor.

GRADUATE WORKSHOPS AND GUEST LECTURES

2022 **Computational Text Analysis Fundamentals: Rtweets & Tidytext**, guest lecturer, Missouri School of Journalism and MU Institute for Data Science & Informatics.

2021 **COMM 6750: Research Methods for Social Networks and Social Media**, guest lecture: "A primer to the Twitter API v2 for Academic Research," Cornell University.

2021 **Topic Modelling and Word Embedding Analysis in R**, guest lecturer, Cornell University.

SERVICE

SERVICE TO THE FIELD

2022-26 **Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Task Force,** Computational Methods Division, International Communication Association. Support participation and inclusive training pathways for scholars using computational methods.

Journal reviewer, International Journal of Public Opinion Research; Mass Communication and Society; Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review.

Conference reviewer, International Communication Association; National Communication Association; Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication;

American Association for Public Opinion Research; International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media; International Conference on Computational Social Science.

2022 **External Reviewer,** Faculty Development Scheme, Research Grants Council of Hong Kong. Reviewed research funding proposal(s) for the University Grants Committee.

SERVICE TO SCHOOL OF JOURNALISM

2026 **Lead, bid to host the 2027 C+J Symposium.** Lead proposal development, planning, and team coordination for the Missouri School of Journalism and Reynolds Journalism Institute bid to host the symposium.

2023-26 **Member, Undergraduate Program Outcomes Assessment Committee.** Contribute to program assessment and improvement; initiated outreach to MU Analytics/Institutional Research to identify usable evidence for assessing critical-thinking and research-skills outcomes.

2023-26 **Graduate program and faculty governance.** Participate in graduate and faculty discussions and decisions, including coordination of graduate education across Journalism and Informatics through the joint appointment.

2023-24 **Member, Reynolds Journalism Institute research group.** Participated in collaborative research on mapping critical information needs.

SERVICE TO INSTITUTE FOR DATA SCIENCE & INFORMATICS

2023-26 **Core Faculty, Ph.D. in Informatics.** Participate in doctoral program governance; member of the Awards Committee.

2023-26 **Core Faculty, M.S. in Data Science & Analytics.** Participate in graduate program governance and student capstone/committee support.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2009-10 **Reporter,** Vietnam Financial Review, Vietnam.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

International Communication Association (2014-present); Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (2014-present); National Communication Association (2014-present); American Association for Public Opinion Research (2014-present); Association of Internet Researchers (2017-present); Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence (2021-present).

METHODS, SOFTWARE & LANGUAGES

Computational methods: natural language processing and large language models; machine learning; topic modeling and embeddings; network analysis; platform and search audits; web and social media data collection.

Other methods: surveys; experiments; quantitative analysis; qualitative and textual analysis.

Programming/software: Python; R; Git; shell scripting; cloud computing; SPSS; LaTeX.

Languages: Vietnamese (native); English (full proficiency); Korean (proficiency).